to India'.[18] Notably, in his thirteen years in the north, west and central India, Alberuni never came across Buddhism, which had by then receded to the east. 'India, as far as known to Alberuni, was Brahmanic, not Buddhistic,' writes Sachau. He 'knew scarcely anything at all about Buddhism, nor had any means for procuring information on the subject'.[19] Clearly, Buddhism's demise from much of India predated the Turko-Persian invasions, as discussed in the previous chapter on Nalanda.

India According to Alberuni

Central to 'the Hindu world of thought', writes Alberuni, 'is that which the Brahmins think and believe, for they are specially trained for preserving and maintaining their religion. And this it is which we shall explain, viz the belief of the Brahmins'. This declaration makes it clear which section of Indian society—and its ideas, beliefs and values—is the one Alberuni mostly describes in *India*.

'The Hindus have numerous books about all the branches of science,' he writes. They 'have books about the jurisprudence of their religion, on theosophy, on ascetics, on the process of becoming god and seeking liberation from the world', on various schools of thought like Samkhya, Mimamsa, Nyaya, Yoga, Lokayata and many more. He feels overwhelmed at first, 'How could anybody know the titles of all of them, more especially if he is not a Hindu, but a foreigner?'

But Alberuni rolls up his sleeves and dives right in. 'I do not spare either trouble or money in collecting Sanskrit books . . . and in procuring for myself, even from very remote places, Hindu scholars who understand them and are able to teach me.' He learns Sanskrit, finding it a difficult language due to its range and complexity, much like Arabic. He observes that the Hindus of north India speak Sanskrit in two registers, a 'vernacular one . . . and a classical one'. He feels lucky to be able to undertake all this learning so freely, and thanks God for the opportunity.

In time, Alberuni reads a large number of Hindu religious, philosophical and astronomical texts. Much of *India* consists of his expositions of Brahminical texts and practices. He highlights choice parts from the Gita, the Upanishads, Patanjali, Puranas, the four Vedas and scientific texts by